The Signaling Gap:

State-Owned Media and the Strategic Management of Sentiment during the Russian Invasion of Ukraine

Proposal

States that depend on a powerful patron for their security do not always have the luxury of saying what they think. Formal diplomatic channels—UN votes, official statements, public breaks—become liabilities when using them risks retaliation from the very power that guarantees a state's survival. Yet when a patron's actions draw international condemnation, silence risks being seen as endorsement. The Russian invasion of Ukraine on February 24, 2022—the largest land war in Europe since World War II—confronted Russia's formal security partners with exactly this bind. States bound to Russia through CSTO and bilateral security agreements had genuine reasons to oppose the invasion—it violated sovereignty norms and threatened economic ties with the West—but open condemnation of a patron willing to use force in its near abroad was not viable. During the Cold War, Soviet-aligned states used state-owned media to communicate positions that formal diplomatic channels could not carry—and Western intelligence analysts learned to read those signals as indicators of genuine preferences (Cohen, 1987). We argue that the same channel Soviet-aligned states once used to signal under constraint remains operative today, and that the 2022 invasion reveals its logic with unusual clarity.

International relations scholarship has predominantly studied state media as a tool of domestic audience management (McCombs, 2002; Guriev & Treisman, 2022). Western governments, however, have monitored state media as a source of international intelligence for decades (Favere, 2024; Monitoring, 2016), treating deviations from official positions as signals of genuine regime preferences (Williams & Blum, 2018). We build on this practitioner insight to argue that state-owned media functions as an informal signaling channel through which constrained states communicate genuine preferences to external audiences—particularly Western governments. The credibility of this channel derives from the nature of state-owned media itself. Because external observers understand these outlets to be under government control, shifts in coverage are read not as independent journalism but as regime choices (Manor, 2019; USIC, 2024). States in our sample are aware of this scrutiny, giving senders reason to believe their signals will be received. The signal is also costly: allowing negative coverage of a security patron risks retaliation from Moscow, making bluffing irrational. Crucially, the institutional separation between government and media outlets also provides deniability if confronted.

Why state media rather than other channels? States facing this dilemma have a range of tools available, and the choice between them is not whether to signal, but a strategic calculus that must balance visibility and risk. The most public instruments—UN votes, formal diplomatic statements—are highly visible and directly attributable, which is precisely what makes them too costly for states bound by security agreements. The least visible alternative—quiet, private diplomatic meetings—avoids provocation but sacrifices credibility; a message delivered behind closed doors is unverifiable by the audiences it is meant to reach and easily dismissed as cheap talk (Fearon, 1997). State-owned media occupies the middle ground. It is public enough to be observed by foreign governments that systematically monitor it, yet it preserves enough institutional distance from official policy that the sending state retains plausible deniability.

We test this argument by exploiting variation in formal security relationships with Russia across twelve states in Russia's near abroad, drawing on a corpus of several hundred thousand newspaper articles published before and after the invasion.[1] Measuring sentiment at this scale poses a practical challenge: the corpus spans multiple languages and countries, making hand-coding infeasible. We employ a generative AI model (GPT-4o) to measure sentiment toward Russia at the article level, benchmarking its performance against a human-coded gold standard of 100 articles. Our identification strategy uses the sharp discontinuity of February 24 to estimate the causal effect of the invasion on media sentiment within each group through a regression discontinuity in time design. To compare across groups, we leverage a Regression Difference-in-Discontinuity Design (RDID), which allows us to estimate whether the discontinuous shift in sentiment differed across security relationships while holding the shock itself constant. The sharp discontinuity substantially reduces confounding concerns, though cross-group comparisons remain correlational; we subject these to extensive robustness checks.

Our findings build sequentially. We first establish that the invasion produced a genuine negative shock to media sentiment toward Russia across the region. We then show that this decline was not uniform: independent media responded significantly more negatively than state-owned media, consistent with strategic management of coverage. The critical test comes in the comparison across security relationships. A domestic audience management account would predict that Russia-aligned states suppress negative coverage to protect the alliance. Instead, we find the opposite: state-owned media in states with Russian security agreements shifted more negatively than state-owned media in neutral states, despite these same states refusing to condemn the invasion through formal diplomatic channels. This pattern is consistent with constrained states using media to signal genuine dissatisfaction to external audiences precisely because formal channels were unavailable.

This paper makes two primary contributions. First, we demonstrate that the signals practitioners have long monitored are theoretically structured and empirically identifiable. The patterns follow directly from alliance constraints: states whose formal channels are constrained produce systematically different media signals than those whose channels remain open, suggesting state media sentiment is a legible instrument of international communication. Second, we identify an understudied mechanism of informal signaling: when formal channels are foreclosed by dependence on a patron, states turn to informal ones, producing signals that follow predictable patterns rooted in their security commitments. Methodologically, the paper demonstrates how generative AI measurement tools can be paired with a regression discontinuity design to enable large-scale, cross-national analysis of media signals in multilingual settings where hand-coding is infeasible. More broadly, the RDID framework we employ—leveraging a sharp, exogenous shock to compare media responses across structurally different groups—offers a generalizable template for studying how different types of states or media systems respond to the same international event.

[1] The twelve states span three categories of alignment. Russia-aligned: Armenia, Azerbaijan, Belarus, and Kazakhstan. Neutral: Georgia, Moldova, Kosovo, and Serbia. NATO-aligned: Albania, Hungary, and Turkey. Ukraine is included in the dataset but excluded from the main analysis given its direct role as the invaded party.

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